

ECONOMIC INTELLIGENCE SERIES

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · April 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Kansas City	74.3
#2	A+	Raleigh	72.4
#3	A+	Hartford	68.6
#4	A+	Las Vegas	68.2
#5	A	Austin	65.4
#6	A	Birmingham	64.2
#7	A	Salt Lake City	63.8

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	D	Portland	22.8
#49	C-	Washington DC	28.7
#48	C-	Baltimore	29.6
#47	C-	Richmond	30.7
#46	C-	Jacksonville	31.9
#45	C	Chicago	34.3
#44	C	Minneapolis	34.6

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	9 cities
B+ / B / B-	23 cities
C+ / C / C-	17 cities
D	1 cities

Data sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) · Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED)
Unemployment, LFP, Earnings, Employment, Weekly Hours sourced from BLS LAUS / SAE.
Building Permits from Census Bureau via FRED. Days on Market from Realtor.com / FRED.

Scoring methodology: percentile ranking across all 50 metros.
Full methodology: SCORING_README.md
Pipeline runs weekly via GitHub Actions.

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · April 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	LFP	DOM
1	Kansas City Kansas City	A+	74.3	3.5%	+7.0%	+1.4%	N/A	45 days
2	Raleigh Raleigh-Cary	A+	72.4	3.0%	+4.0%	+1.7%	N/A	46 days
3	Hartford Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A+	68.6	2.7%	+0.1%	+1.9%	N/A	39 days
4	Las Vegas Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	A+	68.2	5.2%	+6.7%	+1.7%	N/A	52 days
5	Austin Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A	65.4	3.2%	+5.8%	+1.4%	N/A	53 days
6	Birmingham Birmingham	A	64.2	2.2%	-0.5%	+0.5%	N/A	56 days
7	Salt Lake City Salt Lake City-Murray	A	63.8	3.4%	+4.0%	+0.7%	N/A	45 days
8	Dallas Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	A-	62.9	3.6%	+4.4%	+1.0%	N/A	48 days
9	Nashville Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	A-	61.7	3.0%	+2.3%	+0.4%	N/A	53 days
10	Pittsburgh Pittsburgh	B+	57.9	3.6%	+7.0%	+0.3%	N/A	65 days
11	Los Angeles Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B+	55.5	4.8%	+5.4%	+1.8%	N/A	45 days
12	San Francisco San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	B+	55.0	4.1%	+5.5%	+0.7%	N/A	29 days
13	Houston Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	B	54.9	4.2%	+4.1%	+0.7%	N/A	50 days
14	Cincinnati Cincinnati	B	54.9	3.6%	+0.6%	+0.3%	N/A	45 days
15	Atlanta Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	B	54.2	N/A	+6.5%	N/A	N/A	51 days
16	Denver Denver-Aurora-Centennial	B	54.0	3.6%	+4.7%	-0.1%	N/A	38 days
17	Fresno Fresno	B	53.4	8.2%	+8.4%	+1.9%	N/A	51 days
18	Memphis Memphis	B	53.2	4.0%	+6.1%	-0.3%	N/A	62 days
19	San Jose San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	B	51.7	4.0%	+0.7%	+1.7%	N/A	24 days
20	New York New York Newark-Jersey City	B	50.7	4.5%	+5.5%	+0.1%	N/A	51 days
21	Charlotte Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	B	50.4	3.6%	-1.3%	+0.8%	N/A	49 days
22	San Diego San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	B	50.3	4.4%	+4.6%	+0.7%	N/A	38 days
23	Miami Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	B-	49.5	3.5%	+8.4%	-0.7%	N/A	74 days
24	Columbus Columbus	B-	49.4	3.6%	+3.0%	+0.3%	N/A	41 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	LFP	DOM
25	Cleveland Cleveland	B-	49.0	3.4%	-0.8%	+0.6%	N/A	55 days
26	Philadelphia Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	B-	48.3	N/A	N/A	+0.3%	N/A	43 days
27	Phoenix Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	B-	48.1	3.5%	N/A	-0.3%	N/A	54 days
28	Providence Providence-Warwick	B-	48.1	4.3%	+2.8%	+0.6%	N/A	48 days
29	Louisville Louisville-Jefferson County	B-	47.4	3.1%	+2.4%	-0.2%	N/A	45 days
30	Riverside Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	B-	44.8	5.1%	+6.7%	+0.9%	N/A	54 days
31	Seattle Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B-	44.2	5.0%	+9.0%	-0.1%	N/A	34 days
32	Sacramento Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	B-	44.2	4.8%	+3.0%	+1.0%	N/A	39 days
33	San Antonio San Antonio-New Braunfels	C+	43.7	3.7%	+3.4%	+0.4%	N/A	61 days
34	Tampa Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	C+	43.3	4.6%	+8.8%	-0.2%	N/A	66 days
35	Oklahoma City Oklahoma City	C+	42.5	3.6%	+5.4%	-0.5%	N/A	55 days
36	Indianapolis Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	C+	42.0	2.5%	+4.0%	-0.7%	N/A	51 days
37	Grand Rapids Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	C+	41.4	4.0%	+3.9%	-0.4%	N/A	44 days
38	Orlando Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	C+	40.1	4.4%	N/A	+0.5%	N/A	67 days
39	St. Louis St. Louis	C+	38.8	3.5%	+1.4%	+0.2%	N/A	46 days
40	Boston Boston-Cambridge-Newton	C+	38.1	3.9%	+3.4%	N/A	N/A	30 days
41	Virginia Beach Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	C	37.7	3.6%	+10.1%	-0.4%	N/A	36 days
42	Milwaukee Milwaukee-Waukesha	C	35.5	3.1%	+3.5%	-0.8%	N/A	33 days
43	Detroit Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	C	35.2	4.7%	+1.6%	-0.2%	N/A	45 days
44	Minneapolis Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	C	34.6	N/A	+1.5%	-0.1%	N/A	36 days
45	Chicago Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	C	34.3	4.5%	+4.0%	+0.3%	N/A	35 days
46	Jacksonville Jacksonville	C-	31.9	4.6%	+6.4%	-0.5%	N/A	58 days
47	Richmond Richmond	C-	30.7	3.3%	+5.4%	-0.4%	N/A	39 days
48	Baltimore Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	C-	29.6	3.6%	+3.0%	-1.5%	N/A	37 days
49	Washington DC Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	C-	28.7	3.8%	+1.9%	N/A	N/A	N/A
50	Portland Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	D	22.8	4.9%	+5.0%	-1.8%	N/A	49 days

Kansas City

Kansas City

A+

EXCELLENT

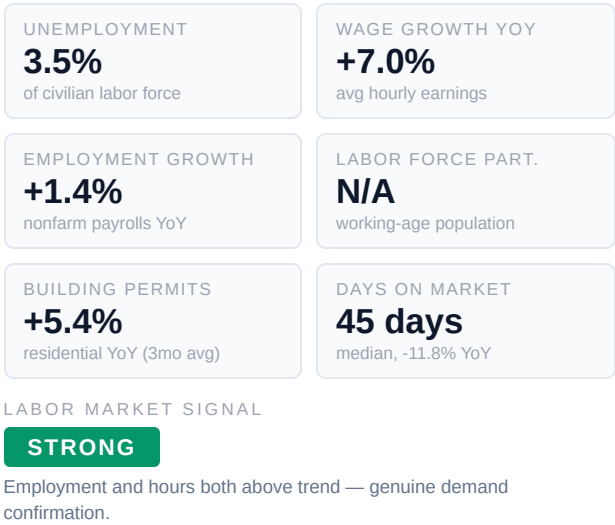
74.3th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City earns an A+ grade, driven by its excellent economic character, with top-tier nonfarm employment growth of +1.39% YoY and labor force growth of +2.10% YoY. The city's wage growth of +6.97% YoY indicates that workers are benefiting from this growth, while employers face increasing labor costs.

The city's affordable cost of living is being tested by a fast-moving housing market, with days on market at 45 days and decreasing by -11.8% YoY. This demand surge is driven by genuine employment growth, as evidenced by above-average building permits growth of +5.41% YoY. The housing market's rapid pace poses a relocation challenge for new hires.

Kansas City offers businesses a thriving economy with rapid job creation and a growing workforce, but the fast-moving housing market poses a significant relocation challenge. The city's affordability advantage is eroding as demand outpaces housing supply, impacting its attractiveness to businesses and workers. Businesses should consider the potential impact on talent attraction and retention when evaluating Kansas City as a location.

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

A+

EXCELLENT

72.4th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+4.0%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.7%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

N/A

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+38.8%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

46 days

median, +4.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Raleigh earns an A+ overall grade, driven by its exceptionally tight labor market with a 3.00% unemployment rate and 1.70% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth. The city has a highly concentrated professional workforce, ranking in the 98th percentile for office and professional worker share. This positions Raleigh as an economically expanding market with a deep talent pool, making it attractive for knowledge-economy businesses and headquarters.

The labor force is growing slowly, at 0.53% year-over-year, which constrains hiring capacity and exacerbates the competitive labor market. The cost of living is among the most affordable, with a score of 1.42. The housing market is stabilizing, with days on market increasing by 4.5% year-over-year to 46 days, and building permits rising 38.82% year-over-year, indicating a healthy normalization.

Raleigh offers businesses a unique combination of talent, affordability, and economic momentum, making it an excellent location for companies seeking to tap into a deep professional workforce. The primary risk lies in labor market constraints limiting hiring capacity, which businesses must consider when evaluating Raleigh as a potential location, weighing the benefits of its strong economy against the challenges of a competitive labor market.

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

A+

EXCELLENT

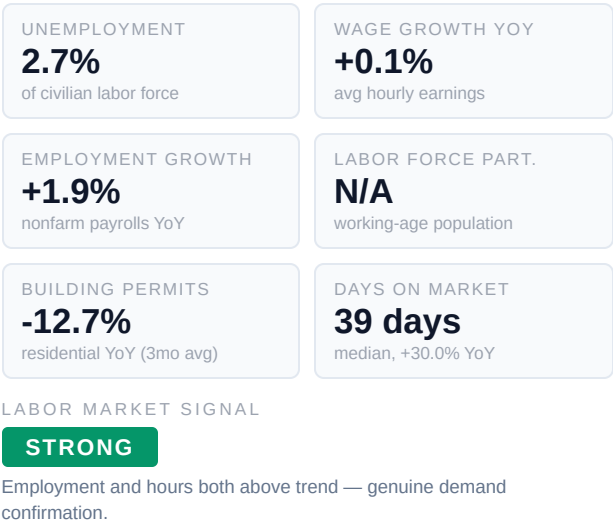
68.6th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Hartford earns an A+ grade, driven by its remarkably tight labor market with an unemployment rate of 2.70% and labor force growth of 2.77% year-over-year. The city's nonfarm employment growth of 1.88% year-over-year indicates strong job creation. This momentum is driven by a highly competitive labor market where businesses face significant hiring competition and workers have substantial leverage. Beneath the surface of economic strength, wage growth has been stagnant, with hourly earnings increasing by only 0.13% year-over-year, a bottom-tier performance. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 30.0% year-over-year to an average of 39 days, and building permits declining by 12.70% year-over-year. This slowdown indicates a potential housing supply squeeze that could impact affordability and workforce attraction.

Hartford offers businesses a highly competitive and expanding economic environment with strong job growth, but the primary risk lies in the potential for a housing supply squeeze and stagnant wage growth, which could erode the city's attractiveness to workers and impact consumer spending. Businesses must carefully weigh these factors to determine whether Hartford's economic momentum can overcome its emerging challenges.

Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

A+

EXCELLENT

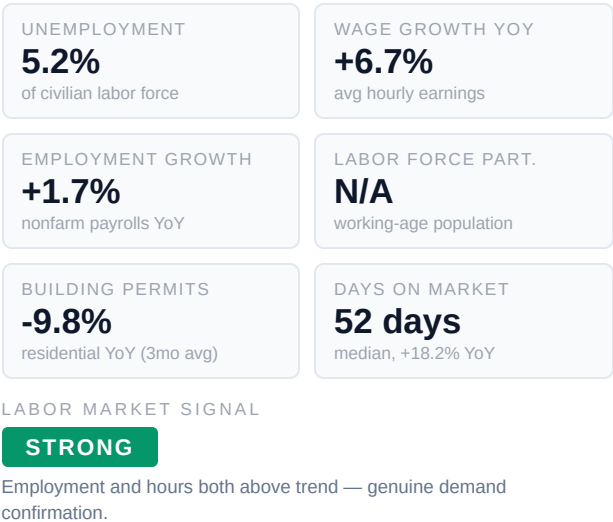
68.2th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Las Vegas earns an A+ grade, driven by its exceptional economic performance. The city's labor market is characterized by strong growth, with nonfarm employment increasing by 1.7% year-over-year and a labor force expansion of 3.24% year-over-year. Wages are rising rapidly, with hourly earnings growing by 6.67% year-over-year, indicating a highly competitive job market.

The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 18.2% year-over-year to an average of 52 days. The unemployment rate of 5.2% is elevated, indicating some labor market slack. The city's 85th percentile ranking for office and professional worker share demonstrates a deep professional talent pool, a significant advantage for knowledge-economy businesses.

Las Vegas offers businesses a highly competitive and growing labor market, with a strong pipeline of skilled workers. The primary risk is labor cost pressures due to rapid wage growth, which could impact businesses' bottom lines. With its strong employment trends and talented workforce, Las Vegas remains an attractive location for businesses, despite some signs of housing market slowdown.

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

A

VERY GOOD

65.4th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Austin earns an overall grade of A, driven by its exceptional labor market performance. The city's low unemployment rate of 3.20% and above-average labor force growth of 1.01% YoY indicate a healthy labor market. Austin also boasts a top-tier cost of living composite score of 1.02, making it one of the most affordable metros, and has a deep professional talent pool, with a 96th percentile rank for office and professional worker concentration.

The city's housing supply metrics, however, are a concern. Building permits are declining sharply by 29.44% YoY, a bottom-tier performance that signals potential future affordability stress and workforce attraction difficulty. Days on market are increasing by 20.4% YoY, with homes taking an average of 53 days to sell, indicating a slowing market. This decline in housing supply poses a risk to the city's economic momentum, particularly given the average employment growth of 1.36% YoY.

Austin offers businesses a unique combination of affordability, a deep professional talent pool, and a healthy labor market, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses and HQ locations. The primary risk lies in the city's declining housing supply, which will impact future workforce attraction and affordability. Decision-makers should carefully consider this risk when evaluating Austin as a business location.

Birmingham

Birmingham

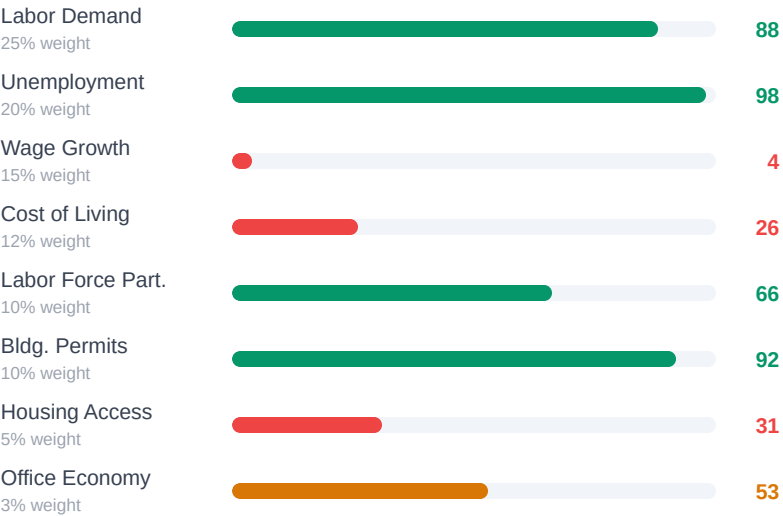
A

VERY GOOD

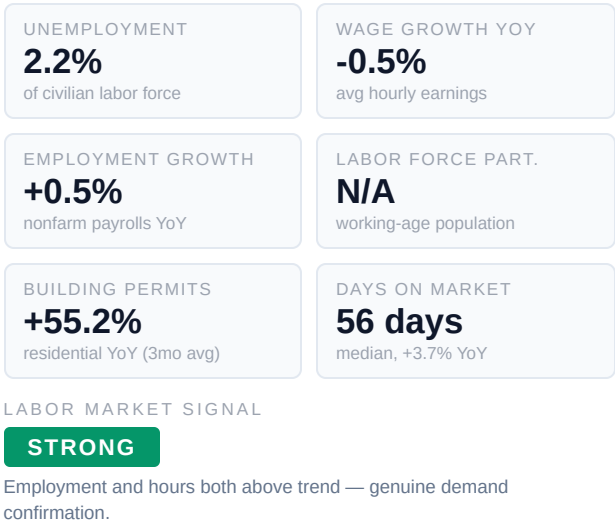
64.2th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham earns a grade of A- due to its highly competitive labor market, with an unemployment rate of 2.20% and a 0.52% year-over-year increase in nonfarm employment. The city's labor force growth is 1.06% year-over-year, outpacing the national average. This strong labor market dynamics indicate an economically expanding market.

The city's housing market is competitive, with homes selling in 56 days on average, but it is slowing, with a 3.7% year-over-year increase in days on market. This slowdown occurs alongside a 55.25% year-over-year increase in building permits, indicating a normalization of the market. Wage growth is stagnant, with a -0.46% year-over-year change, limiting workers' leverage despite the tight labor market.

Birmingham offers a highly dynamic economic environment, with a strong labor market and aggressive housing supply growth. The tight labor market poses a risk for businesses, which may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent due to stagnant wage growth. With a highly competitive labor market and expanding economy, businesses must navigate these challenges to succeed in Birmingham.

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

A

VERY GOOD

63.8th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.4%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+4.0%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.7%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

N/A

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+14.7%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

45 days

median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Salt Lake City earns an overall grade of A, driven by its strong economic character and top-tier nonfarm employment growth of +0.74% YoY. The city's deep professional talent pool, ranking in the 94th percentile for office and professional worker concentration, supports this growth. The below-average cost of living, with a composite index of 1.83, adds to the city's appeal, making it attractive for businesses and workers.

The housing market is highly competitive, with homes selling at an average of 45 days on market, ranking in the 26th percentile. This poses a barrier to talent attraction, as relocating workers face significant time pressure and competition. The city's above-average building permit growth of +14.73% YoY indicates that housing supply is keeping pace with demand, mitigating some of the pressure.

Salt Lake City offers businesses a thriving economy with a deep talent pool and low cost of living. The highly competitive housing market poses a risk, as relocating workers may struggle to secure housing quickly, potentially impacting talent attraction and retention efforts. With its strong economic fundamentals, the city remains an attractive location for businesses, despite the challenges in the housing market.

Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

A-

GOOD

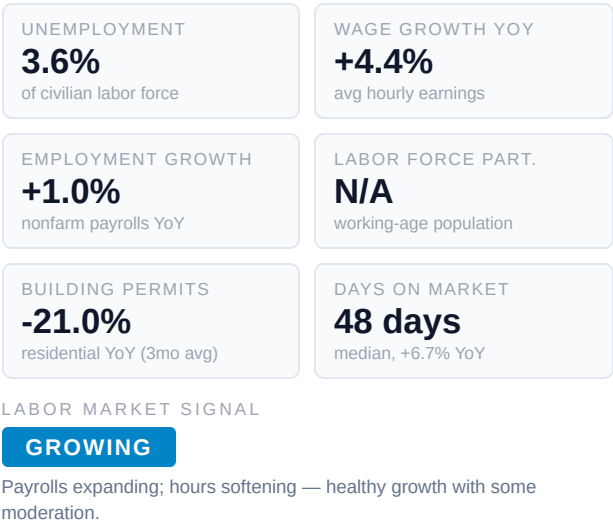
62.9th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area earns an overall grade of A- and ranks in the 62.9th percentile among 50 US metros, with its strong labor market being the single most important takeaway. This strong performance is underpinned by a healthy labor market, with an unemployment rate of 3.60% and above-average nonfarm employment growth of 0.98% year-over-year. The city's cost of living composite score of 1.28 places it in the top tier for affordability.

The city's office and professional worker share is a significant strength, with the city ranking in the 92nd percentile, indicating a deep talent pool that can support knowledge-economy businesses. The sharp decline in building permits, down 20.96% year-over-year, raises concerns about a potential housing supply squeeze, which could lead to affordability and workforce attraction challenges if left unaddressed.

Dallas offers businesses a unique combination of a strong labor market, high affordability, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for investment. The primary risk lies in the potential housing supply squeeze, which could erode the city's affordability advantage and create challenges for workforce attraction if not mitigated through targeted development and planning initiatives.

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

A-

GOOD

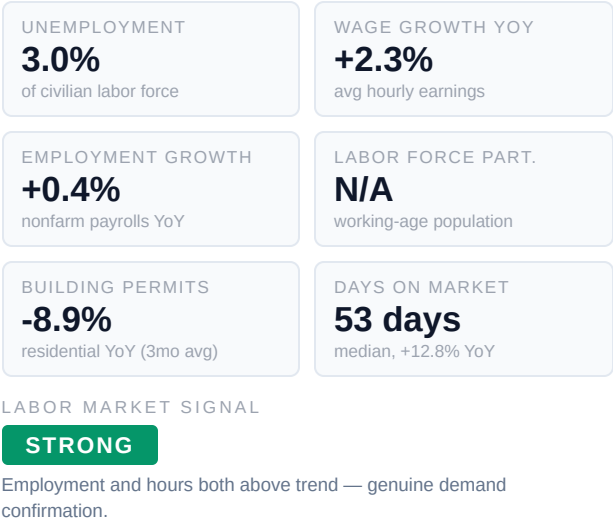
61.7th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Nashville earns an A- grade, driven by its strong labor market and deep professional talent pool. The city's 3.0% unemployment rate indicates a tight labor market, where businesses face significant hiring competition and workers have leverage. This is further reinforced by the 3.42% year-over-year growth in the labor force, signaling a rapidly expanding workforce supply.

Nashville's office and professional worker share ranks in the 89th percentile, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses and headquarters. Wage growth is 2.31% year-over-year, which is sluggish and indicates a lower cost environment for employers but potentially weak worker bargaining power. Employment growth is above average at 0.41% year-over-year, while the housing market is slowing, with homes taking 12.8% more days to sell than last year.

Nashville offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, deep professional talent pool, and above-average job growth, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses. The primary risk is the potential for hiring challenges due to the exceptionally low unemployment rate, which could constrain business expansion plans.

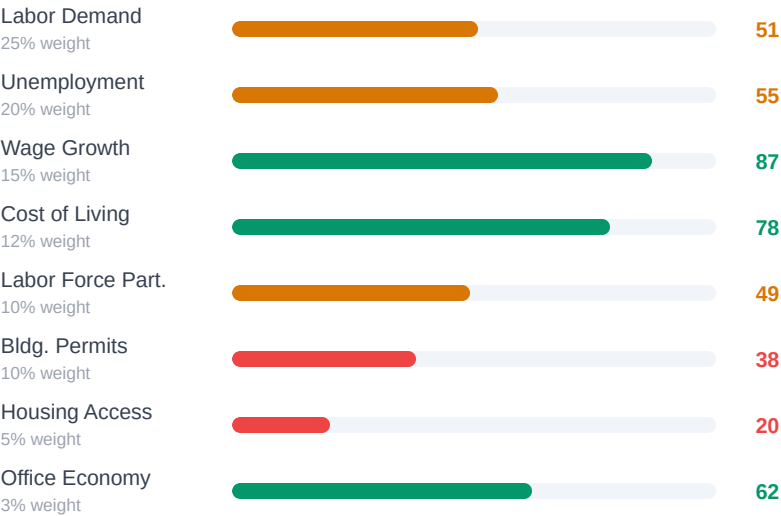
Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

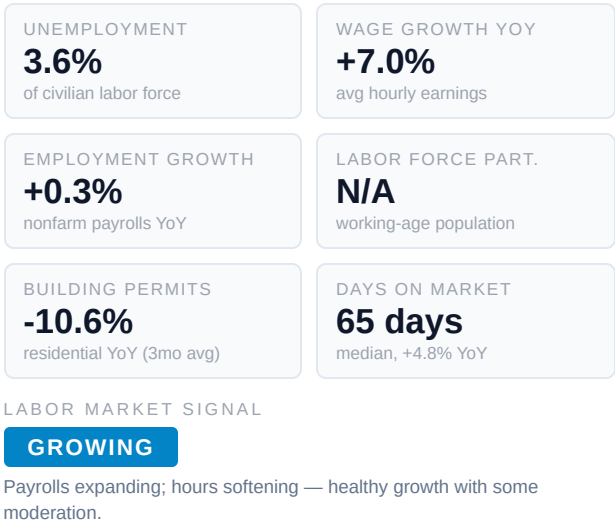
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
57.9th percentile
Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh earns a B+ grade, driven by its top-tier 7.00% year-over-year wage growth, indicating a strong labor market. The city's cost of living composite score is 1.42, below average, making it an attractive location for businesses and workers. An above-average professional workforce further reinforces the city's economic character.

The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 4.8% year-over-year to an average of 65 days, and building permits declining by -10.55% year-over-year. This slowdown could indicate a genuine erosion of demand, rather than a healthy normalization of the market. The city's strong economic indicators make this dynamic noteworthy, as it may impact Pittsburgh's affordability advantage.

Pittsburgh offers a unique combination of strong wage growth, an affordable cost of living, and a professional workforce, making it attractive for investment. The primary risk lies in the potential erosion of demand in the housing market, which could impact the city's long-term affordability and attractiveness to relocating workers, with 7.00% wage growth and a cost of living score of 1.42 being key factors.

Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
55.5th percentile
Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim earns a B+ grade, driven by its strong labor market with nonfarm employment growth of +1.83% YoY and solid wage growth of +5.44% YoY. The city's cost of living composite score is 5.63, placing it in the bottom tier, which constrains talent acquisition and real consumer spending power. This high cost of living is a significant concern for businesses.

The housing market is expanding, with building permits growing aggressively at +20.24% YoY, indicating a potential long-term improvement in affordability. Homes take an average of 45 days to sell, with days on market increasing by +7.1% YoY. This indicates a stabilizing force in the market, driven by strong employment growth and rising permits.

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim offers a strong and expanding labor market, with solid wage growth and an aggressively expanding housing supply. The high cost of living is the primary risk, impacting talent acquisition and consumer spending power. Businesses should factor this into their location decision, considering the need for tailored compensation strategies to attract and retain talent in this market.

San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

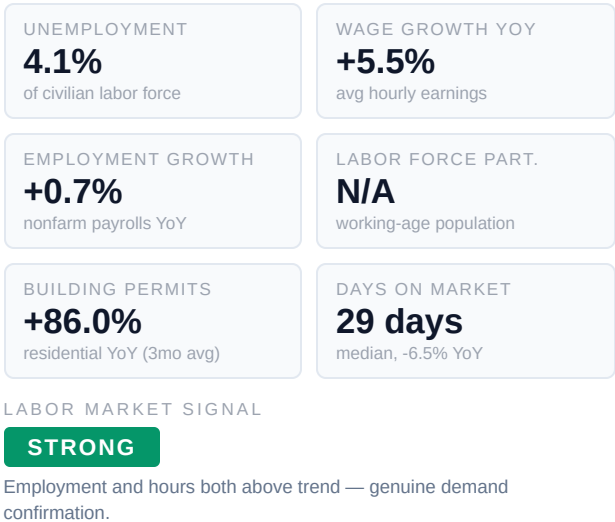
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
55.0th percentile
Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

San Francisco earns a B+ grade, with its strong job market and high wage growth being the most important takeaway. The city's nonfarm employment growth of +0.65% YoY and solid wage growth of +5.54% YoY indicate a healthy expansion, with businesses and workers benefiting from a strong job market. San Francisco has a cost of living composite of 4.52, ranking in the bottom tier, making it one of the most expensive metros.

The housing market is driven by strong demand, with days on market at 29 days and decreasing by -6.5% YoY. The top-tier building permits growth of +86.01% YoY indicates an aggressive expansion of housing supply. Labor force growth is +0.43% YoY, below average, but not a significant constraint given the overall job market strength.

San Francisco offers businesses a thriving job market with strong wage growth, but the high cost of living and intense housing competition pose a primary risk, hindering talent attraction and retention. Companies must weigh the benefits of a dynamic economy against the challenges of accommodating employees in one of the most expensive cities in the country, with a cost of living composite that ranks in the bottom tier.

Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

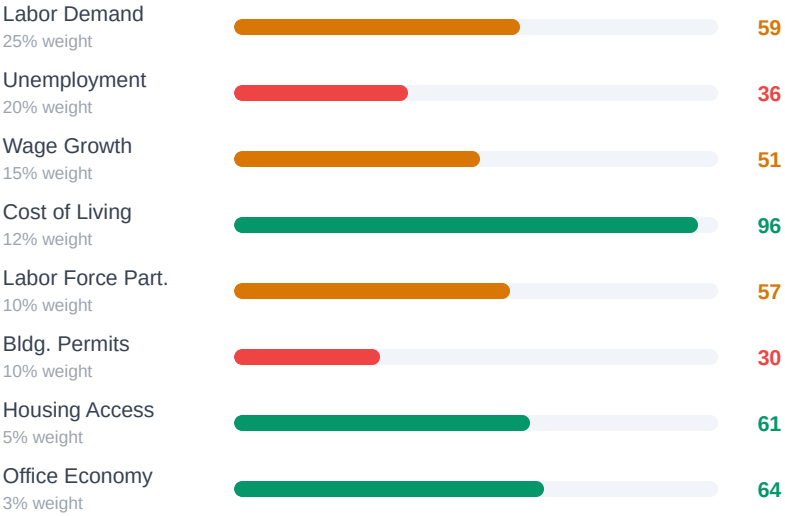
B

AVERAGE

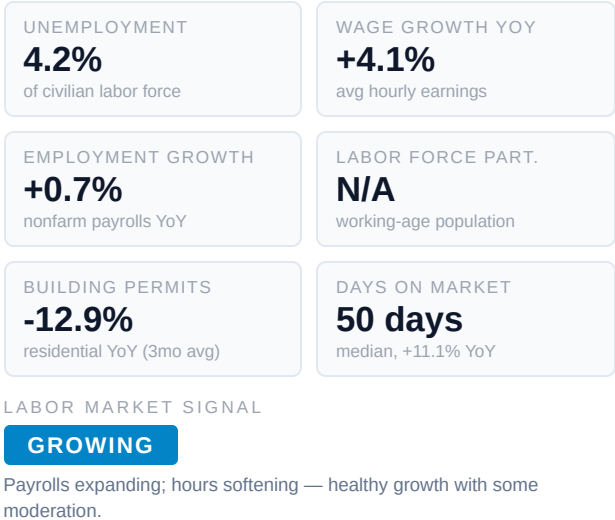
54.9th percentile

Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Houston earns a B grade, driven by its high affordability ranking as one of the most affordable metros. The city's cost of living composite score of 1.01 ranks in the 96th percentile, offering a strong cost advantage for businesses and residents. This affordability is offset by an elevated unemployment rate of 4.20%, signaling labor market slack and weakened local consumer demand.

The housing market shows signs of demand erosion, with days on market increasing by 11.1% year-over-year to an average of 50 days. Building permits have declined by 12.89% year-over-year, indicating that housing supply is not keeping pace with demand. The city's above-average office and professional worker share, ranking in the 64th percentile, is a positive for office-dependent businesses.

Houston's attractive cost structure is a significant draw for businesses, with its high affordability ranking being a major advantage. However, the city's slowing housing market and declining building permits pose a risk to local consumer demand and labor market vitality, making labor market weakness the primary concern.

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

B

AVERAGE

54.9th percentile

Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		61
Unemployment 20% weight		85
Wage Growth 15% weight		8
Cost of Living 12% weight		28
Labor Force Part. 10% weight		15
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		94
Housing Access 5% weight		92
Office Economy 3% weight		81

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.6% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +0.6% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.3% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE PART. N/A working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS +57.5% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 45 days median, +21.6% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati earns a B grade, with its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 3.60% being the most important takeaway about this city. The city's nonfarm employment growth remains above average, at 0.30% year-over-year, signaling a healthy economic expansion. However, this is paired with a shrinking civilian labor force, which contracted by 0.79% year-over-year, indicating a structural headwind for businesses seeking to expand their headcount.

The low unemployment rate is accompanied by stagnant wage growth of 0.55% year-over-year, indicating that workers do not have as much leverage as the headline rate implies. The city's housing market is slowing, with homes taking 21.6% more days to sell than last year, resulting in an average of 45 days on market. This slowdown is accompanied by an aggressive expansion of housing supply, with building permits increasing by 57.47% year-over-year.

Cincinnati offers businesses a deep professional talent pool, with an office and professional worker share ranking in the 81st percentile, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses. The city's tight labor market, with a shrinking civilian labor force, poses a primary risk that may constrain hiring and expansion plans.

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

B

AVERAGE

54.2th percentile

Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		71
Unemployment 20% weight		19
Wage Growth 15% weight		79
Cost of Living 12% weight		74
Labor Force Part. 10% weight		34
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		50
Housing Access 5% weight		45
Office Economy 3% weight		40

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT N/A of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +6.5% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH N/A nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE PART. N/A working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS N/A residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 51 days median, +8.5% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL N/A Insufficient data to determine labor market scenario.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Atlanta earns a B grade, with its 54.2th percentile ranking out of 50 US metros driven by severe labor market weakness, as evidenced by an unemployment rate in the bottom tier at the 19th percentile. The city's labor market is characterized by this weakness, but hourly earnings are increasing by 6.47% year-over-year, placing it in the 79th percentile. This indicates that employed individuals are seeing meaningful income gains, with wage growth being a notable aspect of the city's economy.

The labor force is growing slowly, at just 0.51% year-over-year, which constrains hiring capacity. Atlanta has a cost of living advantage, with a composite score of 1.52, ranking in the 74th percentile. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 8.5% year-over-year, to an average of 51 days. This slowdown is a sign of normalization, given the strong wage growth and affordable cost of living.

Atlanta offers a business environment with a skilled workforce and low costs, making it an attractive location for companies. The primary risk is the labor market's underlying weakness, which could limit the city's long-term growth potential and pose a challenge for businesses looking to expand or hire. With its unique combination of strengths and weaknesses, Atlanta presents a complex narrative for businesses to consider.

Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

B

AVERAGE

54.0th percentile

Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		43
25% weight		
Unemployment		89
20% weight		
Wage Growth		57
15% weight		
Cost of Living		70
12% weight		
Labor Force Part.		11
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		23
10% weight		
Housing Access		67
5% weight		
Office Economy		57
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.6% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +4.7% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH -0.1% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE PART. N/A working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS -16.0% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 38 days median, +8.6% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Denver earns an overall grade of B, with its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 3.60% being the most important takeaway. This rate reflects a tight labor market, where businesses face significant hiring competition and workers have considerable leverage. The city's civilian labor force has contracted by 1.50% year-over-year, indicating a structural headwind for businesses seeking to expand their headcount.

The low unemployment rate is paired with a shrinking labor force, which masks a shrinking workforce rather than just low layoffs. The city's housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 8.6% year-over-year to an average of 38 days, indicating a moderate buyer's market. Building permits have fallen by 15.96% year-over-year, which will tighten housing supply and put upward pressure on prices.

Denver offers businesses a highly competitive labor market, but with significant hiring challenges due to a shrinking workforce. The primary risk for businesses considering location in Denver is the potential for labor shortages and rising costs, which could erode the city's affordability advantage and hinder growth prospects.

Fresno

Fresno

B

AVERAGE

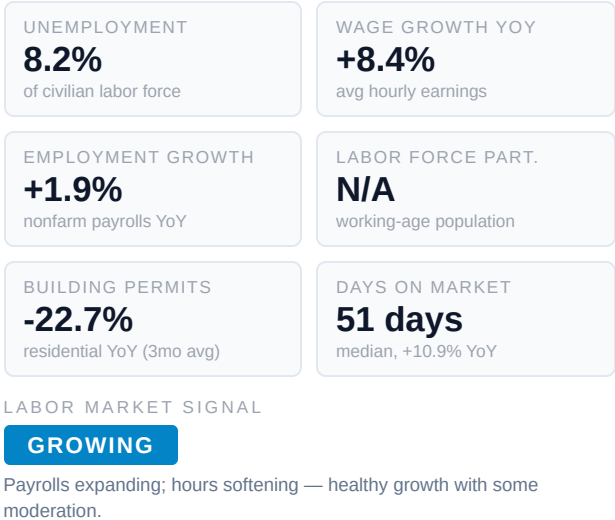
53.4th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Fresno earns an overall grade of B, with its 8.20% unemployment rate being the most critical issue. The city's nonfarm employment growth of 1.86% year-over-year and labor force growth of 1.87% year-over-year indicate a rapidly expanding market. This growth is driven by a strong hiring pipeline, with wage growth of 8.37% year-over-year, which is excellent for workers but presents a cost pressure for employers.

Fresno's housing supply is contracting, with building permits declining sharply by 22.67% year-over-year. The city's low professional and office worker concentration, ranking in the 4th percentile, poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses. This decline in building permits, combined with strong employment growth, indicates a housing supply squeeze is building, which could deteriorate affordability and workforce attraction.

The city's high unemployment rate and declining building permits pose significant challenges for businesses. Fresno offers a rapidly expanding market with a strong hiring pipeline, but businesses must carefully consider these factors when making location decisions. The tension between employment growth and housing supply constraints makes it essential for companies to weigh the benefits and risks of operating in Fresno, where a strong economy is offset by labor market and housing challenges.

Memphis

Memphis

B

AVERAGE

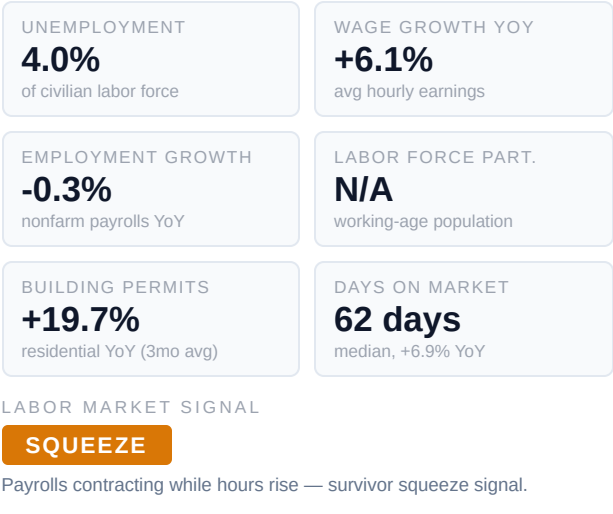
53.2th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Memphis earns a B grade, ranking in the 53.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with its stagnant job market being the primary concern. The city's nonfarm employment growth is -0.35% year-over-year, while labor force growth is 1.36% and wage growth is 6.12%. This indicates a market where workers are being attracted, but job creation is lagging.

Memphis has a significant cost advantage, with a cost of living composite score of 0.51, making it one of the most affordable metros. This affordability, combined with strong wage growth, is a major draw for businesses and workers. The city's low concentration of office and professional workers, ranking in the 2nd percentile, poses a constraint for knowledge-economy businesses.

The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 6.9% year-over-year, indicating softening demand. Memphis offers businesses an attractive cost environment and a growing labor force, but the stagnant job market and potential demand erosion are primary risks. Businesses can navigate the city's complexities and capitalize on its advantages by carefully considering these factors and planning accordingly.

San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

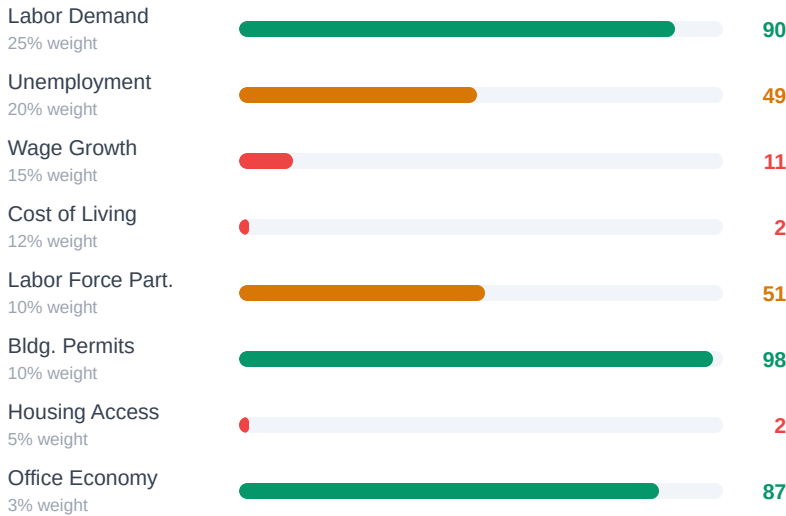
B

AVERAGE

51.7th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+0.7%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.7%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

N/A

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+195.1%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

24 days

median, +9.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

San Jose earns a top grade due to its rapid job creation, with nonfarm employment growth at +1.69% year-over-year. The city's economy is further bolstered by an extremely high rate of building permits, up +195.09% year-over-year, indicating an aggressive expansion of the housing supply. This growth has led to a deepening affordability crisis, as the cost of living composite scores a mere 2nd percentile, making it one of the most expensive metros.

The city's strong employment growth contrasts with stagnant wage growth at +0.65% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier. Workers are not benefiting from the economic expansion, limiting consumer spending power. The housing market, with an average of 24 days on market, is slowing down, with days on market increasing by +9.1% year-over-year. This slowing market is a healthy normalization, given the strong employment growth and rising building permits, which will eventually ease affordability pressures.

San Jose offers businesses a deep professional talent pool, with an office and professional worker share ranking in the 87th percentile. The city's strong economic momentum makes it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses. However, the extremely high cost of living constrains talent acquisition and limits real consumer spending power, offsetting the benefits of the city's economic growth.

New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

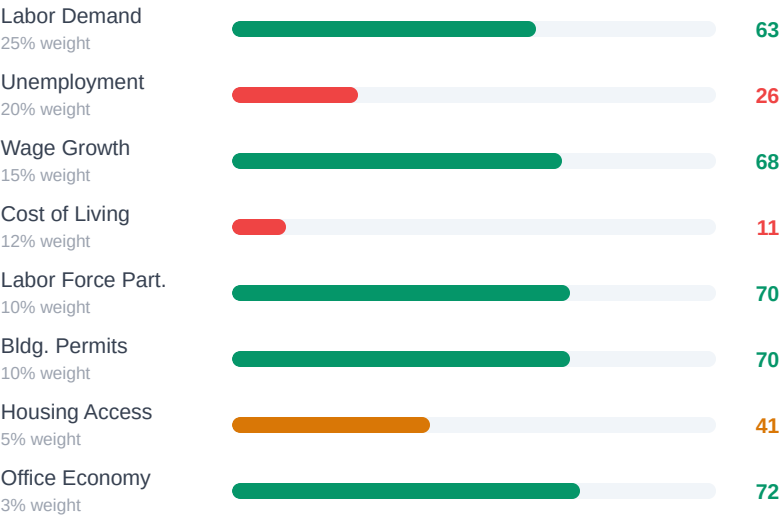
B

AVERAGE

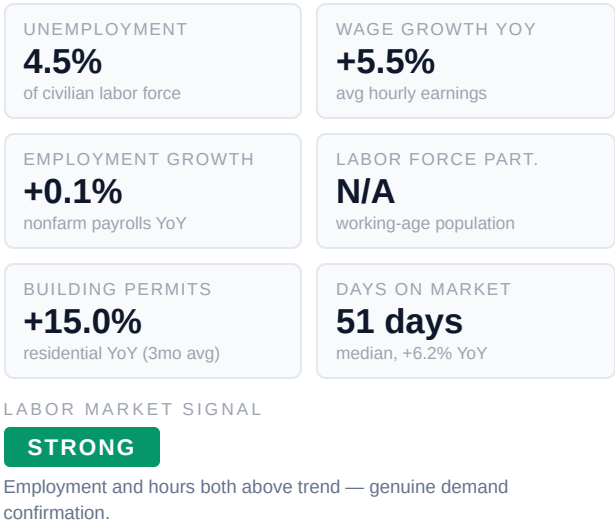
50.7th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

New York earns a B+ grade, with its strong labor market and solid wage growth being the most important takeaway. The city's nonfarm employment increased by 0.13% year-over-year, and its civilian labor force grew by 1.20% year-over-year. Hourly earnings rose by 5.47% year-over-year, supporting the city's healthy expansion.

The city's high cost of living, with a composite index score of 4.93, poses a significant constraint on talent acquisition and real consumer spending power. This is a key consideration, as it offsets the advantage of the city's above-average professional workforce, ranking in the 72nd percentile. The slowing housing market, with days on market increasing by 6.2% year-over-year, is a stabilizing force given the strong employment growth and rising building permits.

New York offers businesses a strong and expanding labor market, with solid wage growth and a highly skilled workforce. However, the high cost of living is the primary risk, constraining talent acquisition and consumer spending power. Businesses must carefully consider the trade-offs of operating in this market, weighing the benefits of the city's labor market against the drawbacks of its high cost of living.

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

B

AVERAGE

50.4th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Charlotte earns a B grade, with its 50.4th percentile ranking out of 50 US metros driven by a strong hiring pipeline, as evidenced by a 2.28% year-over-year labor force growth rate. The city's nonfarm employment growth is above average, at 0.85% year-over-year. However, hourly earnings have declined by 1.28% year-over-year, a concerning sign for consumer spending.

The housing market is a concern, with building permits declining sharply by 39.50% year-over-year, indicating a potential housing supply squeeze. Homes are taking longer to sell, with days on market increasing by 13.9% year-over-year to an average of 49 days. This slowdown in the housing market, combined with declining building permits, indicates that demand is eroding.

Charlotte offers a deep professional talent pool, with an office and professional worker share ranking in the 83rd percentile, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses. The primary risk is a potential housing supply squeeze, which could lead to affordability stress and workforce attraction difficulties, ultimately undermining the city's economic growth.

San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

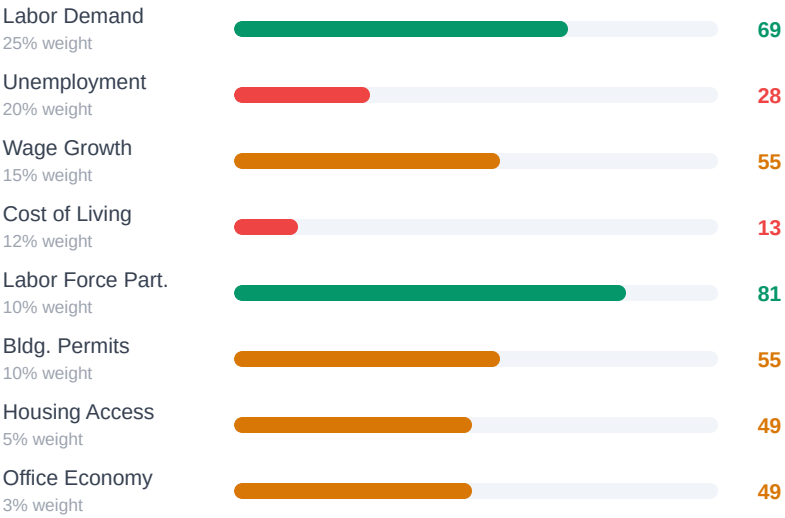
B

AVERAGE

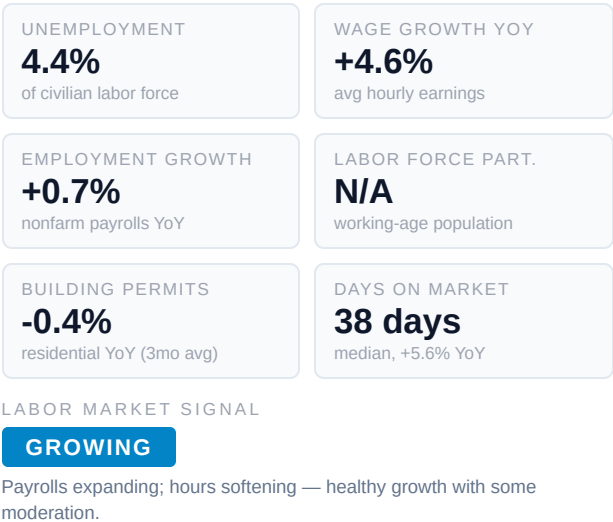
50.3th percentile

Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

San Diego earns an overall grade of B, with its strong labor market pipeline being the single most important takeaway about this city. The city's labor force growth is +1.66% YoY, ranking in the top tier at 81st percentile. Nonfarm employment growth is +0.70% YoY, above average. However, the unemployment rate is 4.40%, signaling labor market slack and weakened local consumer demand.

The cost of living in San Diego is a significant constraint, with a composite score of 4.90, placing it in the bottom tier at 13th percentile. This high cost of living limits the city's appeal for talent acquisition and real consumer spending power. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by +5.6% YoY to an average of 38 days.

San Diego's strong labor force growth and above-average employment growth make it an attractive location for businesses. However, the high cost of living and slowing housing market pose significant risks, constraining talent acquisition and consumer spending power. Businesses should carefully consider these factors when making location decisions, weighing the benefits of a strong labor market against the drawbacks of decreased affordability.

Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

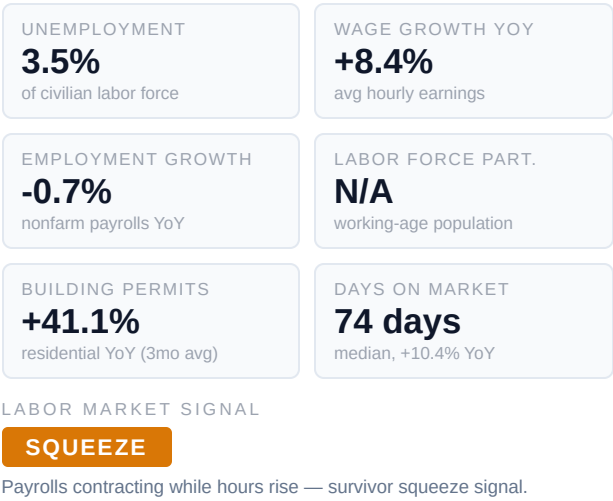
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.5th percentile
Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Miami earns a grade of B- due to its stagnant employment growth, with nonfarm employment growth at -0.70% year-over-year. The city's job market is contracting, a significant concern, but wages are growing at +8.39% year-over-year, making existing jobs more lucrative. The housing market is expanding, with building permits up +41.11% year-over-year, which will help alleviate pressure on affordability.

The labor market's mixed health is characterized by stagnant employment growth and a slowing housing market, with days on market increasing by +10.4% year-over-year to 74 days. Miami's above-average cost of living, with a composite score of 3.14, means businesses must offer wage premiums to attract talent. The city has a strong office and professional worker share, ranking in the 68th percentile.

Miami offers businesses a highly skilled and expensive workforce, with a rapidly expanding housing supply that will help with long-term affordability. The primary risk is the city's stagnant employment growth and potential demand erosion, which will make it challenging for businesses to find and retain talent, and require them to offer higher wages to compete.

Columbus

Columbus

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.4th percentile
Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.6%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.0%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.3%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

N/A

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+8.7%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

41 days

median, +10.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus earns a B- grade, with its low unemployment rate of 3.60% being the single most important takeaway about this city. The city's labor force growth is 0.35% YoY and nonfarm employment growth is 0.29% YoY, indicating a constructive but challenging market. The cost of living is affordable, with a composite score of 1.84.

The housing market is slowing down, with days on market increasing by 10.8% YoY, and homes now sitting on the market for an average of 41 days. This slowdown, combined with weak employment growth, indicates demand erosion rather than healthy normalization. The office and professional worker share is above-average, ranking in the 77th percentile, which is a positive for office-dependent businesses.

Columbus offers a stable, albeit slow-growing, labor market and an affordable cost of living. However, the primary risk for businesses is the potential for demand erosion, driven by weak employment growth and a slowing housing market. Decision-makers should approach Columbus with caution, carefully weighing the city's advantages against its economic challenges, particularly in terms of hiring capacity and workforce supply, with the city ranking in the 49.4th percentile among 50 US metros.

Cleveland

Cleveland

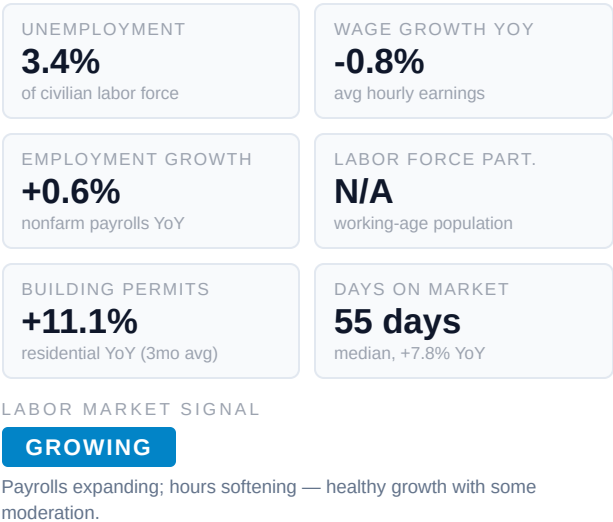
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.0th percentile
Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland earns a top-tier grade due to its strong and expanding labor force, with a year-over-year growth rate of 1.80%. This growth is not translating to wage increases, as hourly earnings have declined by 0.77% over the same period, indicating stagnant or declining real wages. The city's labor force is growing, but workers have limited leverage.

The housing market in Cleveland is characterized by mixed signals, with building permits increasing by 11.14% year-over-year and days on market increasing by 7.8% to an average of 55 days. This suggests a potential normalization of the market after a period of rapid growth, rather than a decline in demand. The strong labor force growth and above-average permit growth support this scenario.

Cleveland offers a growing and expanding labor force, but businesses should be aware of the potential risks of softening demand and limited workforce leverage. The declining wage growth and slowing housing market may impact consumer spending and demand, affecting the overall viability of the market. With a growing labor force and mixed housing market signals, businesses must carefully consider these factors when evaluating Cleveland as a potential location.

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
48.3th percentile
Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Philadelphia earns a B- grade, with its labor market weakness being the most significant concern. The city's unemployment rate ranks in the bottom tier, flagging potential consumer spending risks. The labor market is a significant concern, with the unemployment rate being a key indicator of this weakness.

The housing market is slowing, with homes taking 43 days to sell on average, a 10.3% increase year-over-year, indicating a slow and buyer-friendly market. Building permits are growing at a moderate pace of 4.14% year-over-year, but this does not provide a clear verdict on whether the market is stabilizing or softening.

Philadelphia's slow and buyer-friendly housing market could be beneficial for workers relocating to the area, but the primary risk is the city's labor market weakness, which indicates underlying economic softness and demand erosion. The city ranks 48.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, highlighting the need for closer investigation into its economic dynamics.

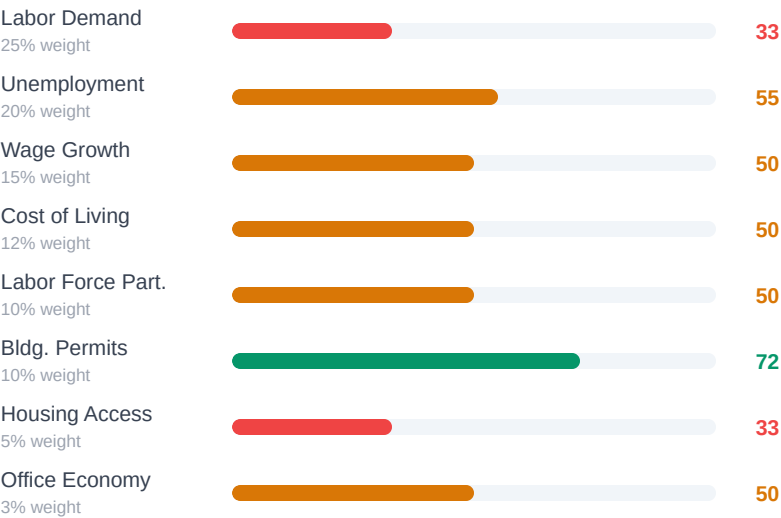
Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
48.1th percentile
Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Phoenix earns a B- grade, with its lackluster nonfarm employment growth being the most significant concern. The metro area ranks in the 48.1th percentile out of 50 US metros, driven by a 0.28% year-over-year decline in nonfarm employment, positioning it in the 33rd percentile. The housing market is characterized by a 16.86% year-over-year increase in building permits, but days on market have lengthened by 5.9% to an average of 54 days.

The rise in days on market, coupled with below-average employment growth, indicates a potential demand erosion scenario. Homes are taking more days to sell, even as new supply comes online, which suggests a genuine decline in demand rather than a healthy normalization. This narrative is reinforced by the lack of strong wage growth or labor force expansion, which would typically accompany a thriving economy.

Phoenix's slowing job market and potential demand erosion in the housing sector pose a risk to businesses considering relocation. The city's weakening economic foundation could impact the availability and quality of the workforce, making it a less attractive location for investment and growth. With a ranking in the 48.1th percentile, Phoenix's economic profile is a concern for businesses looking to invest in the area.

Providence

Providence-Warwick

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
48.1th percentile
Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		71
Unemployment 20% weight		15
Wage Growth 15% weight		26
Cost of Living 12% weight		0
Labor Force Part. 10% weight		83
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		83
Housing Access 5% weight		94
Office Economy 3% weight		70

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.3% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +2.8% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.6% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE PART. N/A working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS +23.5% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 48 days median, +33.3% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Providence earns a grade of C+ due to its severe labor market weakness, with an unemployment rate of 4.30% posing a high risk to consumer spending. The city's labor force growth is 1.69% year-over-year, indicating a rapidly expanding workforce supply. Providence has a cost of living composite score of 7.36, ranking in the bottom tier, making it one of the most expensive metros and constraining talent acquisition and real consumer spending power.

The city's housing supply is expanding aggressively, with building permits increasing by 23.50% year-over-year, a top-tier performance. Days on market have risen by 33.3% to 48 days, indicating a slow and buyer-friendly market. This slowdown is a stabilizing force, given the city's above-average employment growth of 0.60% and strong labor force expansion.

Providence offers a unique combination of a rapidly expanding workforce and an aggressively growing housing supply, but its high cost of living and labor market weakness pose significant risks. The city's expensive nature and unemployment rate outweigh its positives, making it a challenging location for businesses that rely heavily on consumer spending or require a large, affordable workforce.

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

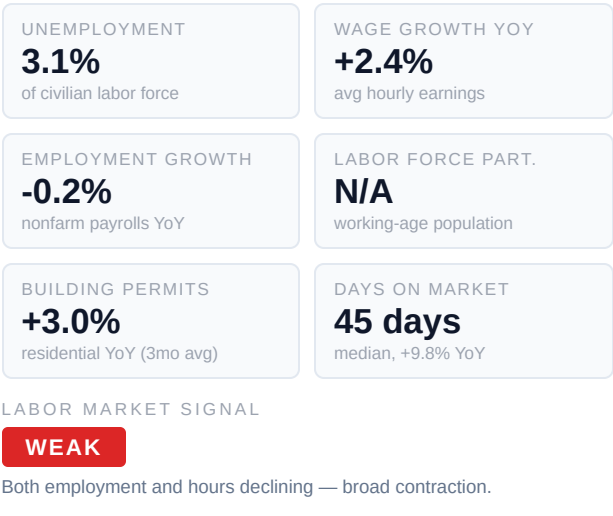
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
47.4th percentile
Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Louisville earns a B+ grade, with its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 3.10% being the most important takeaway about this city. This low rate indicates a competitive hiring environment where workers have leverage. The city's labor force growth is 0.38% YoY and nonfarm employment growth is -0.24% YoY, which constrains the labor market's strength due to a shallow pool of available workers.

The city's wage growth is 2.36% YoY, below average, which signals weak worker bargaining power or softening demand. The cost of living composite score is 3.37, below average, indicating that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 9.8% YoY to an average of 45 days.

Louisville offers a competitive labor market with low unemployment, but poses the risk of constrained hiring capacity due to a shallow labor pool. Businesses considering locating in Louisville must navigate a tight labor market with limited room for growth, requiring strategic recruitment and retention strategies to attract and retain top talent.

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

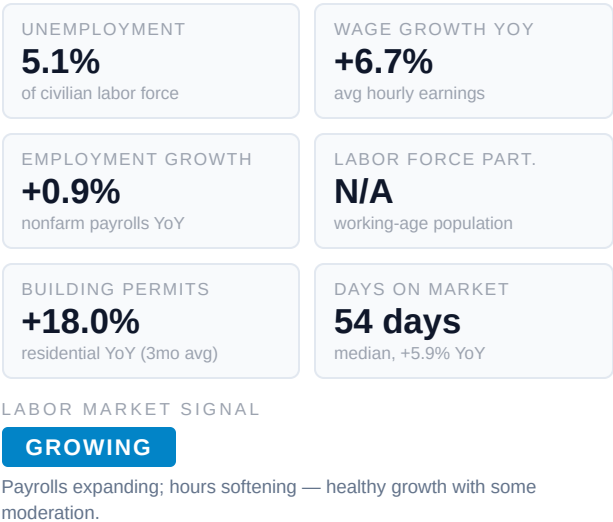
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.8th percentile
Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Riverside earns a B- grade, with labor market weakness being the most critical issue, as evidenced by an unemployment rate of 5.10% and below-average nonfarm employment growth of +0.88% YoY. The city's hourly earnings rose by +6.68% YoY, a top-tier performance indicating a competitive labor market. This contrast between labor market weakness and strong wage growth presents a complex economic landscape.

The cost of living is above average, with a composite score of 3.12, which, combined with rapid wage growth, pressures businesses to offer premium wages to attract talent. The office and professional worker share is remarkably low, ranking in the 0th percentile, posing a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by +5.9% YoY to 54 days, indicating softening demand in the face of weak employment growth.

Riverside's labor market weakness and high cost of living are the primary risks for businesses considering this location. The city's talented workforce is a benefit, but businesses must weigh this against the potential costs and challenges of attracting and retaining top talent in a competitive market. With an overall ranking in the 44.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, Riverside presents a unique set of challenges and opportunities for businesses to navigate.

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.2th percentile
Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Seattle earns a B+ grade, with its labor market weaknesses posing the most significant challenge to businesses. The city faces severe labor market challenges, with an unemployment rate of 5.00% and a shrinking civilian labor force, down 0.65% year-over-year. This structural headwind is a significant concern for businesses seeking to expand their headcount. Hourly earnings are rising 9.02% year-over-year, indicating a highly competitive labor market that poses cost pressures for employers.

Seattle boasts an above-average professional workforce, ranking in the 66th percentile. The housing market is slowing down, with a 9.7% year-over-year increase in days on market, and homes now taking 34 days to sell on average. This slowing market, combined with weak labor force growth and high unemployment, raises concerns about demand erosion.

The primary risk for businesses considering locating in Seattle is the city's labor market weaknesses, which limit their ability to expand and grow. Despite offering a highly skilled and competitive workforce, the city's rapidly rising wages and slowing housing market signal broader economic softness. Businesses must carefully weigh the costs and benefits of operating in this market, considering the trade-offs between a talented workforce and the challenges of a tight labor market.

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.2th percentile
Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		84
25% weight		
Unemployment		15
20% weight		
Wage Growth		28
15% weight		
Cost of Living		20
12% weight		
Labor Force Part.		70
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		26
10% weight		
Housing Access		65
5% weight		
Office Economy		32
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.8% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +3.0% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.0% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE PART. N/A working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS -15.5% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 39 days median, +8.3% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Sacramento earns an overall grade of B- and ranks in the 44.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with strong job creation being its most notable economic feature. The metro area has nonfarm employment growth of +1.00% YoY, placing it in the top tier. However, this is offset by a high unemployment rate of 4.80%, indicating labor market weakness.

The cost of living composite score of 4.25 makes Sacramento one of the most expensive metros, constraining talent acquisition and consumer spending power. The decline in building permits by -15.51% YoY, combined with the high cost of living, will exacerbate affordability issues and hinder workforce attraction. Homes now take an average of 39 days to sell, with days on market increasing by +8.3% YoY, indicating a moderating housing market.

The primary risk to Sacramento's attractiveness is a potential housing supply squeeze, driven by declining building permits and a high cost of living. This could undermine the area's appeal to workers and impact businesses' ability to attract and retain talent. With a strong job creation environment, Sacramento offers opportunities for businesses, but these caveats must be carefully considered.

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

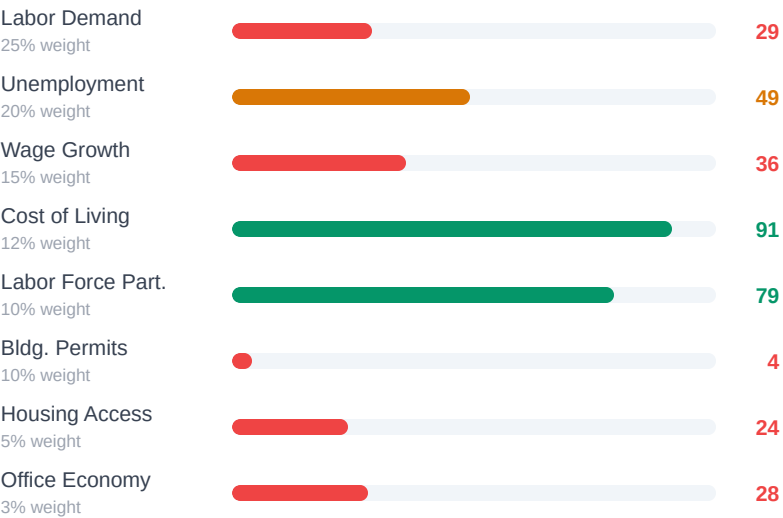
C+

POOR

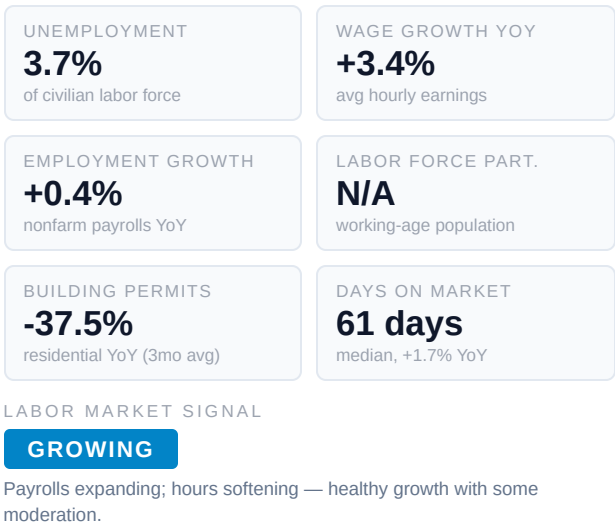
43.7th percentile

Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

San Antonio earns a grade of B+ due to its affordable cost of living, with a composite index score of 1.09. The city's labor force is growing at an above-average rate of +1.47% YoY, indicating a positive workforce supply. However, wage growth is sluggish at +3.43% YoY, signaling weak worker bargaining power or softening demand.

The housing market is experiencing a sharp decline in building permits, down -37.55% YoY, indicating a contracting housing supply. Homes take 61 days to sell on average, and the days on market have increased by +1.7% YoY, indicating a slowing market due to demand erosion. The city's professional talent pool ranks in the 28th percentile, which may constrain specialized or senior roles.

San Antonio's slowing economic growth, with a nonfarm employment growth rate of +0.43% YoY, poses a primary risk. The decline in building permits and slowing housing market may lead to future affordability stress and workforce attraction difficulties. Businesses must carefully consider these factors when making location decisions, weighing the benefits of an affordable cost of living against the potential drawbacks of a slowing economy.

Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

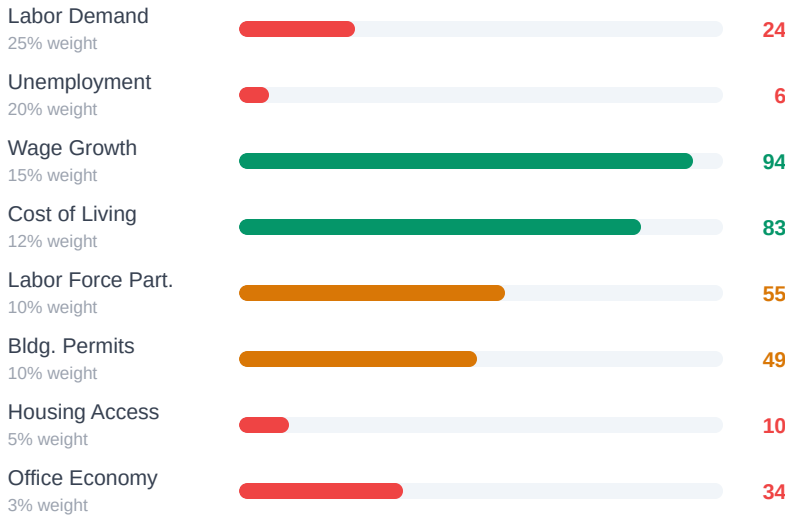
C+

POOR

43.3th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.6%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+8.8%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.2%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

N/A

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-8.6%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

66 days

median, +15.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Tampa earns a C+ overall grade, with its labor market weakness being the most significant concern. The city's unemployment rate of 4.60% indicates a labor market with considerable weakness, and the -0.22% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth signals economic deceleration. Hourly earnings have risen by 8.81% year-over-year, a top-tier performance that puts pressure on labor costs for employers.

Tampa's cost of living composite score of 1.41 makes it one of the most affordable metros, but the housing market is slowing. The days on market have increased by 15.8% year-over-year, with homes taking an average of 66 days to sell. This trend, combined with a below-average office and professional worker share, poses constraints for specialized or senior roles.

The city's strong wage growth amidst weak employment growth indicates a mix shift toward higher-paying jobs rather than broad labor market strength. Tampa offers businesses an affordable cost of living and a talented workforce with rising wages, but the primary risk lies in its labor market weakness and potential constraints in attracting specialized talent. The city's economic deceleration and slowing housing market demand careful consideration from decision-makers.

Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

C+

POOR

42.5th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.6%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+5.4%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.5%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

N/A
working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+20.1%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

55 days
median, +17.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City earns a grade of C due to its struggling labor market, with a nonfarm employment growth rate of -0.54% year-over-year. The city's labor force growth rate is 0.23% year-over-year, indicating a slow expansion of the workforce. This contraction in job opportunities ranks the city in the bottom 6th percentile.

The city's cost of living composite score of 1.11 places it in the top 89th percentile, making it one of the most affordable metros in the dataset. However, the low office and professional worker share, ranking in the 17th percentile, poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 17.0% year-over-year and homes taking an average of 55 days to sell.

Oklahoma City's solid wage growth of 5.38% year-over-year is a positive note, but it is offset by labor market challenges. The city's affordability can be a strong draw for talent and investment, but the struggling labor market, with weak employment growth and a low concentration of professional workers, limits its appeal for certain types of businesses.

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

C+

POOR

42.0th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		18
Unemployment 20% weight		96
Wage Growth 15% weight		45
Cost of Living 12% weight		6
Labor Force Part. 10% weight		21
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		43
Housing Access 5% weight		74
Office Economy 3% weight		23

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 2.5%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +4.0%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY -0.7%	LABOR FORCE PART. working-age population N/A
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -10.3%	DAYS ON MARKET median, +15.9% YoY 51 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood earns an overall grade of C+, with its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 2.50% being the most important takeaway. The city's low unemployment rate indicates a tight labor market, where businesses face significant hiring competition and workers have considerable leverage. The cost of living composite score of 5.25 places Indianapolis in the bottom tier, making it one of the most expensive metros, which can constrain talent acquisition and consumer spending power.

The labor force is growing slowly, with a year-over-year growth rate of -0.36%, resulting in a shallow pool of available workers. The high cost of living and limited professional talent pool, ranked in the 23rd percentile, exacerbate hiring challenges for specialized or senior roles. Nonfarm employment growth has declined by 0.66% year-over-year, indicating a stagnant job market.

The city's economic stagnation, coupled with its high cost of living, hinders a company's ability to attract and retain top talent, ultimately impacting its growth and competitiveness. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 15.9% year-over-year to an average of 51 days, indicating softening demand in the face of weak employment growth. Businesses must carefully consider these factors when making location decisions in Indianapolis.

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

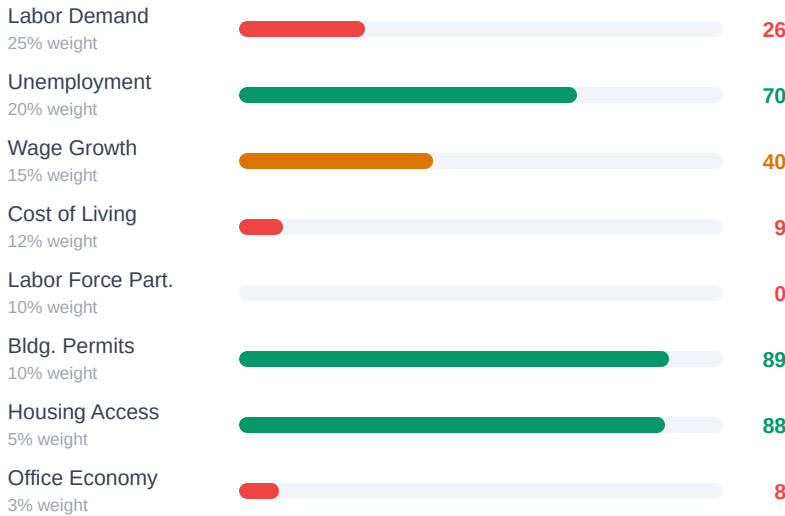
C+

POOR

41.4th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.9%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.4%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

N/A

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+55.2%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

44 days

median, +15.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

8 Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Grand Rapids earns a C+ grade, with its low unemployment rate of 4.00% masking a concerning contraction in the civilian labor force, which has shrunk by 4.96% year-over-year. This indicates a shrinking workforce, rather than just low layoffs. The city's labor market is tight, but its workforce is declining.

The city has a high cost of living, ranking in the 9th percentile, making it one of the most expensive metros. The office and professional worker share is also in the bottom tier, ranking in the 8th percentile, posing a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses. In contrast, the housing supply is expanding, with building permits increasing by 55.17% year-over-year.

The housing market is slowing, with days on market rising by 15.8% to an average of 44 days, and employment growth is weak at -0.43% year-over-year. This combination signals demand erosion. Businesses must be cautious of the high cost of living and the potential for demand erosion, with the constrained labor pool posing a primary risk to their ability to expand and grow.

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

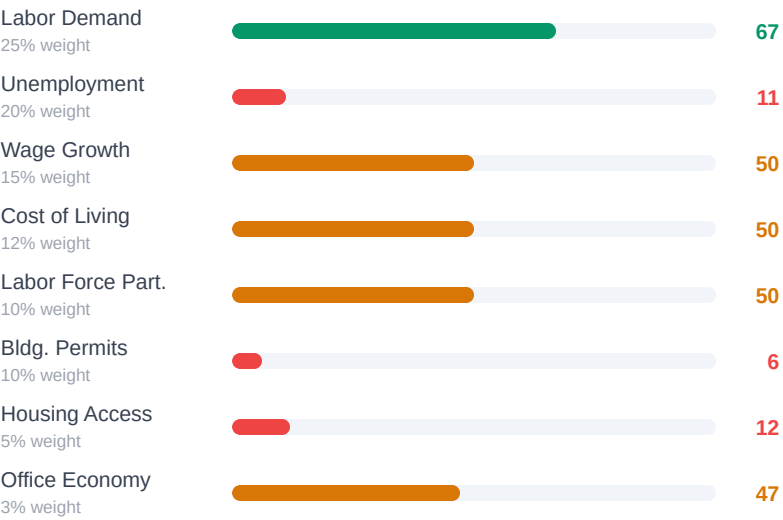
C+

POOR

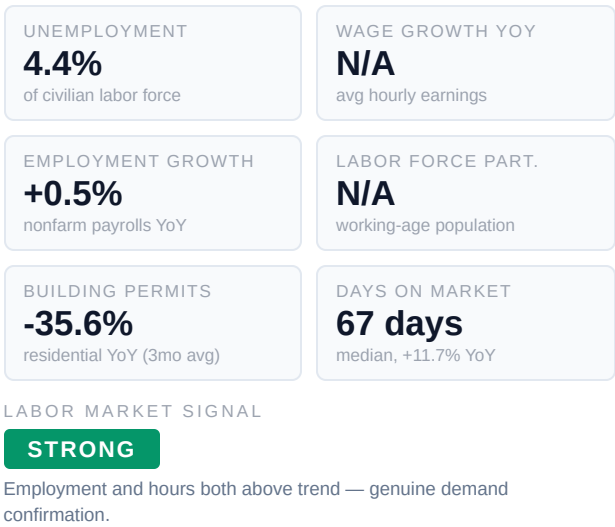
40.1th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Orlando earns a C+ overall grade, with its struggling labor market and housing supply constraints being the most significant concerns. The city's unemployment rate of 4.40% indicates a labor market weakness that will impact consumer spending. The sharp decline in building permits, down 35.64% year-over-year, contracts the housing supply, exacerbating affordability issues and hindering workforce attraction.

Orlando's nonfarm employment growth is a positive indicator, with a 0.46% year-over-year increase, signaling a healthy expansion. Homes are taking 11.7% more days to sell than last year, with an average of 67 days on market, due to softening demand. This trend is driven by the decline in building permits, posing a risk of demand erosion rather than a healthy normalization of the market.

Orlando offers a growing economy with above-average job growth, but its labor market weaknesses and housing supply constraints pose significant risks. The contracting housing supply and slowing market will cause affordability stress and relocation challenges, ultimately impacting businesses' ability to attract and retain talent.

St. Louis

St. Louis

C+

POOR

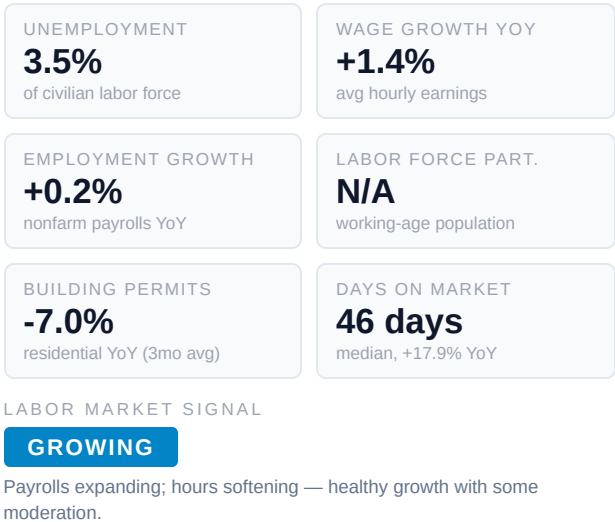
38.8th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis earns an overall grade of C+ and ranks in the 38.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with stagnant job growth being the primary concern. The city's labor market is characterized by nonfarm employment increasing by only 0.17% year-over-year, placing it in the bottom tier, and hourly earnings rising by just 1.41% year-over-year, also in the bottom tier. The unemployment rate is 3.50%, but this does not offset the overall labor market constraint.

The city's housing market is slowing, with homes taking 46 days to sell on average, and this duration increasing by 17.9% year-over-year. This trend indicates a shift towards a buyer's market, which could be beneficial for workers relocating to the area. The low office and professional worker share, ranking in the 19th percentile, further constrains the city's appeal to knowledge-economy businesses.

St. Louis offers a cost of living with a composite score of 3.29, making it an affordable option. However, this advantage is offset by significant labor market and housing market risks, driven by weak job growth and a slowing housing market, which could undermine the city's economic stability and limit opportunities for growth.

Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

C+

POOR

38.1th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Boston earns a C+ overall grade, with its high costs and labor market weakness being the most significant concerns. The city's unemployment rate of 3.90% indicates a labor market that is not absorbing workers as effectively as its peers. The cost of living composite score of 4.36 places Boston among the most expensive metros, constraining talent acquisition and real consumer spending power.

The housing market in Boston presents a challenging picture, with days on market increasing by 20.0% year-over-year to an average of 30 days. This slowing pace of sales, combined with below-average building permit growth of -14.97% year-over-year, signals softening demand. Sluggish wage growth of +3.37% year-over-year also contributes to weakening demand, as workers have less disposable income to spend on housing and other goods.

Boston offers businesses a highly educated and skilled workforce, but at a high cost. The primary risk for businesses considering location in Boston is demand erosion, driven by high costs, labor market weakness, and a slowing housing market, which could impact consumer spending power and business growth. With these factors in mind, businesses must carefully weigh the benefits and drawbacks of operating in Boston.

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

C

VERY POOR

37.7th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.6%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+10.1%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.4%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

N/A

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-46.8%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

36 days

median, -5.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Virginia Beach earns a C grade, ranking 37.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, due to its struggling labor market. The civilian labor force has declined by 2.41% year-over-year, and nonfarm employment growth is below average at -0.41% year-over-year. This indicates a labor market with significant slack, impacting local consumer demand.

The metro area has top-tier wage growth, with hourly earnings rising by 10.08% year-over-year. This strong wage growth contrasts with the stagnant employment picture, indicating a shift towards higher-paying jobs rather than broad labor market health. The housing market is characterized by a sharp decline in building permits, down 46.79% year-over-year, and homes sell quickly in just 36 days.

Virginia Beach offers strong wage growth and an affordable cost of living, with a composite score of 1.59. However, labor market and housing supply constraints pose a risk to the area's long-term growth prospects. Businesses must carefully weigh these factors when considering the location, as the potential for constraints to limit growth is a primary concern, with the area's fast-moving housing market and declining labor force being key challenges.

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

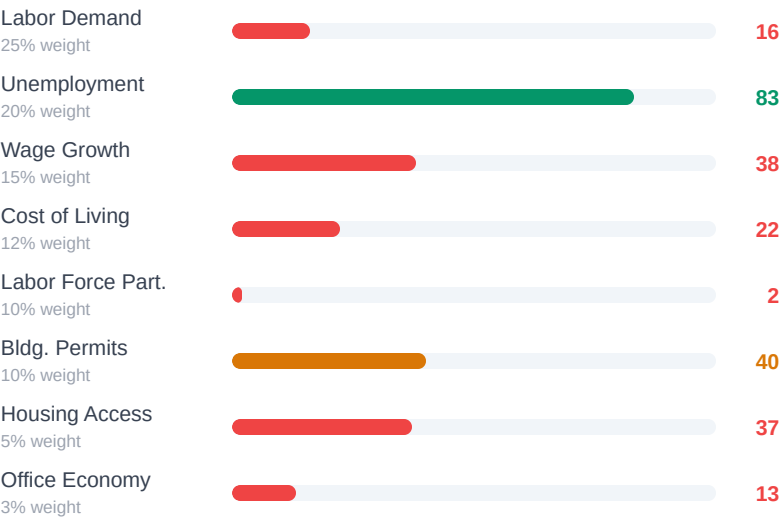
C

VERY POOR

35.5th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Milwaukee earns a B+ grade, with its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 3.10% being the most important takeaway about this city. This tight labor market indicates a highly competitive hiring environment where workers have significant leverage. The city's civilian labor force has contracted by 3.11% year-over-year, posing a structural headwind for businesses seeking to expand their workforce.

The low concentration of office and professional workers, ranking in the 13th percentile, poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses. The housing market, with homes selling in 33 days, is slowing down, with a 6.5% year-over-year increase in days on market, signaling softening demand in the context of weak employment growth. Nonfarm employment growth has stalled, with a -0.75% year-over-year change, pointing to a broader economic slowdown.

Milwaukee's labor market is constrained by a shrinking workforce and limited professional talent pool. The primary risk for businesses considering location in Milwaukee is the potential for demand erosion, driven by weak employment growth and a slowing housing market, which limits the city's ability to support long-term economic expansion. This risk is a key consideration for businesses evaluating Milwaukee as a potential location.

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

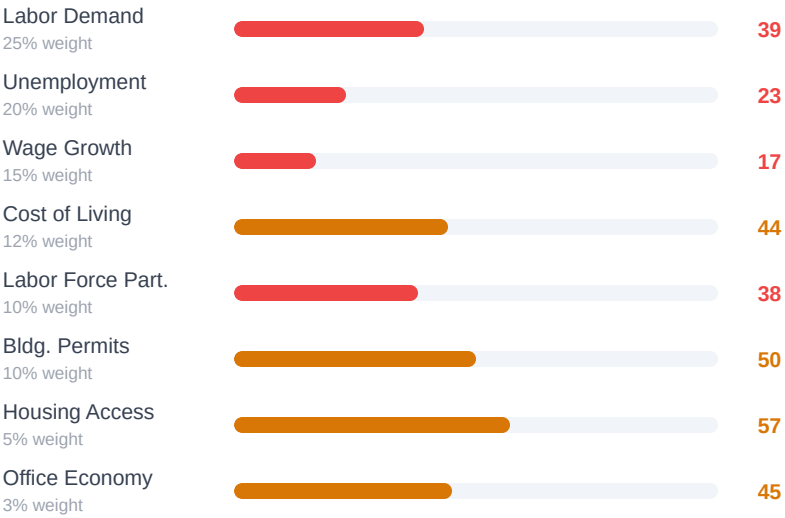
C

VERY POOR

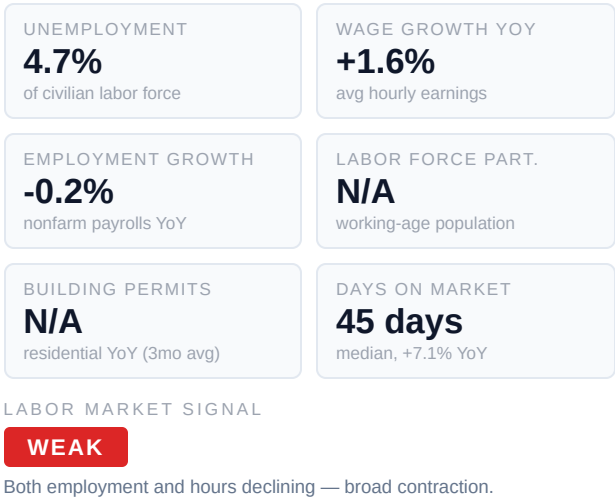
35.2th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Detroit earns a C grade, with its sluggish labor market being the most important takeaway. The city's unemployment rate of 4.70% and stagnant wage growth of 1.58% year-over-year indicate a labor market with significant slack, weakening local consumer demand. The nonfarm employment growth of -0.16% year-over-year signals economic deceleration, a risk signal worth watching.

The housing sector reveals market tensions, with a 7.1% year-over-year increase in days on market, suggesting a slowing market. Weak employment growth and average building permits point to demand erosion rather than a healthy normalization. The stagnant labor force growth of 0.59% year-over-year and bottom-tier wage growth exacerbate these concerns, indicating a softening market with limited workforce leverage.

Detroit's labor market offers easier hiring due to its elevated unemployment rate, but this comes with the risk of weakened local consumer demand. The city's economic deceleration and potential demand erosion may impact long-term growth and stability, making it a primary caveat for businesses considering location in Detroit.

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

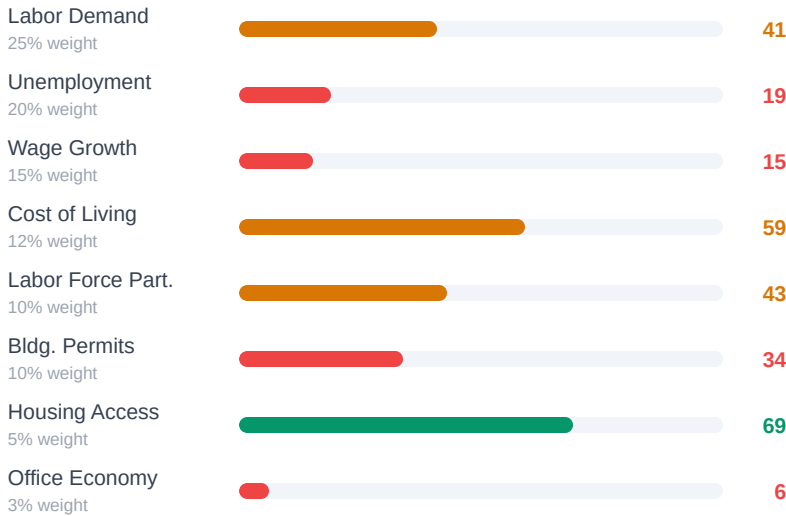
C

VERY POOR

34.6th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

N/A

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.5%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.1%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

N/A

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-12.2%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

36 days

median, +9.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

6 Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington earns an overall grade of C, reflecting a labor market with significant weaknesses, most notably its high unemployment rate and stagnant wage growth. The city's unemployment rate ranks in the 19th percentile, and wage growth is +1.47% YoY, placing it in the bottom tier. The office and professional worker share is also low, ranking in the 6th percentile, posing a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses.

The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 9.1% YoY to an average of 36 days, and building permits declining by 12.25% YoY. This decline in building permits indicates that demand is eroding, rather than simply normalizing. The low office and professional worker share exacerbates this concern, limiting the city's ability to attract and retain high-skilled workers.

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington's labor market challenges and slowing housing market pose risks for businesses reliant on skilled workers. The city's potential for demand erosion and labor market weakness could hinder growth and competitiveness, making it a critical consideration for businesses evaluating this location.

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

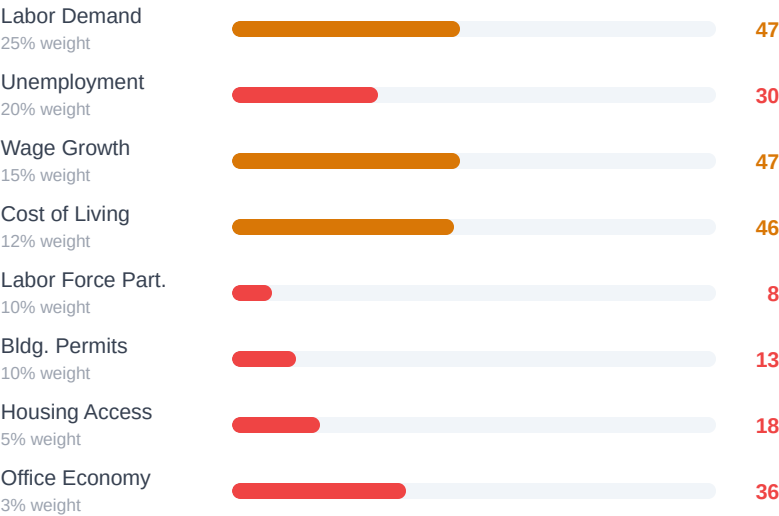
C

VERY POOR

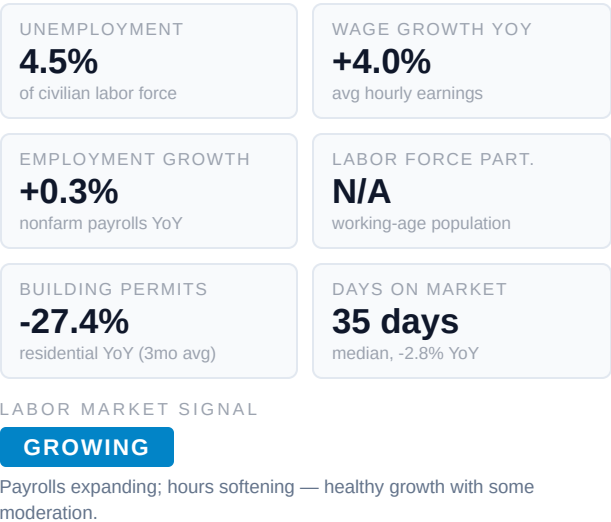
34.3th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Chicago earns a C grade, ranking 34.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with its labor market slack and rapidly tightening housing market posing significant risks to businesses. The city's unemployment rate of 4.50% signals a labor market with slack, making hiring easier, but also weakening local consumer demand. The civilian labor force is shrinking at a rate of -1.72% YoY, a significant structural headwind for businesses seeking to expand their headcount.

The housing market is characterized by supply contraction, with building permits declining sharply by -27.41% YoY, while homes are selling faster, with days on market averaging 35 days, a -2.8% YoY change. This indicates a thin-supply illusion, rather than genuine demand strength, as the market is heating up due to a lack of available homes. The rapid pace of home sales poses a significant relocation challenge for new hires, who will face intense competition for limited housing options.

Chicago's shrinking labor force and tight housing market pose significant risks to businesses, particularly in attracting and retaining talent. The city's below-average office and professional worker share constrains growth, and the intense competition for housing may outweigh any advantages of a slightly softer labor market. With a labor force decline and housing supply contraction, businesses must carefully consider these challenges when evaluating Chicago as a potential location.

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

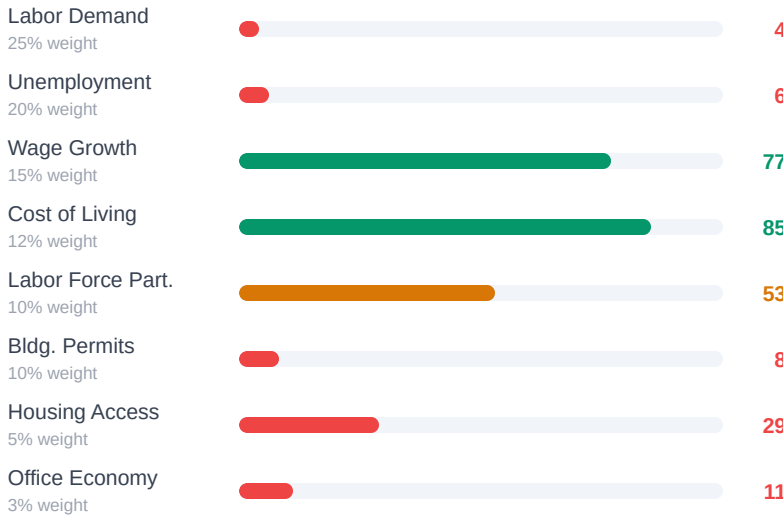
C-

CRITICAL

31.9th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.6%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+6.4%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.5%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

N/A

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-32.7%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

58 days

median, +1.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Jacksonville earns a grade of C due to its severe labor market weakness, with an unemployment rate of 4.60% and nonfarm employment growth of -0.49% year-over-year. The city's contraction story is further exacerbated by a sharp decline in building permits, down 32.70% year-over-year, indicating a housing supply that is contracting and leading to future affordability stress. Jacksonville boasts a significant cost advantage, with a cost of living composite score of 1.29, ranking in the top tier and making it one of the most affordable metros in the dataset.

The housing market is slowing down, with days on market increasing by 1.8% year-over-year to an average of 58 days. This slowdown, combined with weak employment growth and declining building permits, indicates a demand erosion scenario, where fewer qualified buyers are entering the market due to economic softness. The city's low professional and office worker concentration, ranking in the 11th percentile, poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses.

Jacksonville's economic weaknesses, particularly its high unemployment rate and low professional worker concentration, outweigh its cost advantages, making it a challenging location for businesses that rely on a skilled and growing workforce. The city's strong wage growth of 6.38% year-over-year is a positive note, driven by a mix shift towards higher-paying jobs. Despite this, the primary risk is the city's struggling labor market and declining housing supply, which will lead to workforce attraction difficulties.

Richmond

Richmond

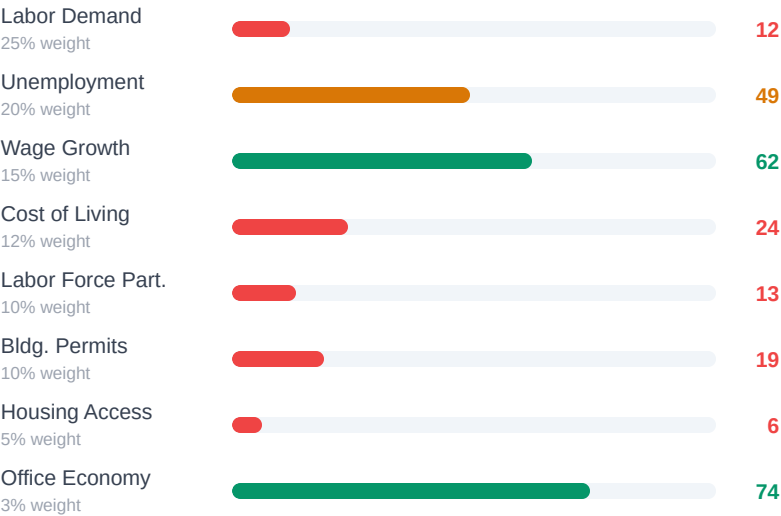
C-

CRITICAL

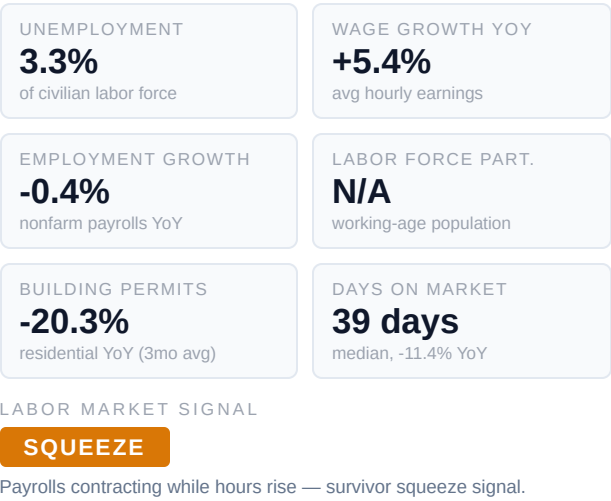
30.7th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Richmond earns a grade of C due to its contractionary labor market, with a -0.36% year-over-year change in nonfarm employment growth and a -1.22% year-over-year decline in the civilian labor force. This results in job losses and a shrinking workforce, posing significant structural headwinds for businesses seeking to expand their operations. Richmond boasts solid wage growth of 5.36% year-over-year, which supports consumer spending but exerts cost pressure on businesses.

The city's housing market is complex, with building permits declining sharply by -20.27% year-over-year, contracting the housing supply and leading to future affordability stress and workforce attraction difficulties. Homes are selling rapidly, with an average of 39 days on market and a -11.4% year-over-year change, indicating a fast-moving market that poses relocation challenges for new hires.

Richmond offers businesses a low-cost environment, with a cost of living composite score of 3.78. However, its shrinking labor force and potentially overheated housing market pose significant risks, making it essential for companies to carefully weigh the benefits and drawbacks of locating in Richmond, as they may face challenges in attracting and retaining talent.

Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

C-

CRITICAL

29.6th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		2
25% weight		
Unemployment		30
20% weight		
Wage Growth		30
15% weight		
Cost of Living		63
12% weight		
Labor Force Part.		19
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		36
10% weight		
Housing Access		96
5% weight		
Office Economy		26
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.6% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +3.0% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH -1.5% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE PART. N/A working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS -11.1% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 37 days median, +27.6% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Baltimore earns a C- grade, with its struggling labor market being the primary concern, marked by a bottom-tier nonfarm employment growth of -1.46% YoY and a shrinking civilian labor force, down 0.62% YoY. This contraction has led to an elevated unemployment rate of 3.60%, signaling labor market slack and weakened local consumer demand. The city's labor market woes are a significant challenge for businesses.

The cost of living in Baltimore is affordable, with a score of 1.85, ranking in the 63rd percentile. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 27.6% YoY to an average of 37 days, indicating a slow and buyer-friendly market. This slowdown is a sign of demand erosion, given the weak employment growth and declining building permits, down 11.14% YoY.

Baltimore's slowing housing market and declining building permits exacerbate the risk posed by its struggling labor market, making it a challenging location for businesses seeking to expand and attract top talent. The city's professional talent pool ranks in the 26th percentile, posing constraints for businesses seeking specialized or senior roles. With a weak labor market and limited talent pool, businesses must carefully consider these factors when evaluating Baltimore as a potential location.

Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

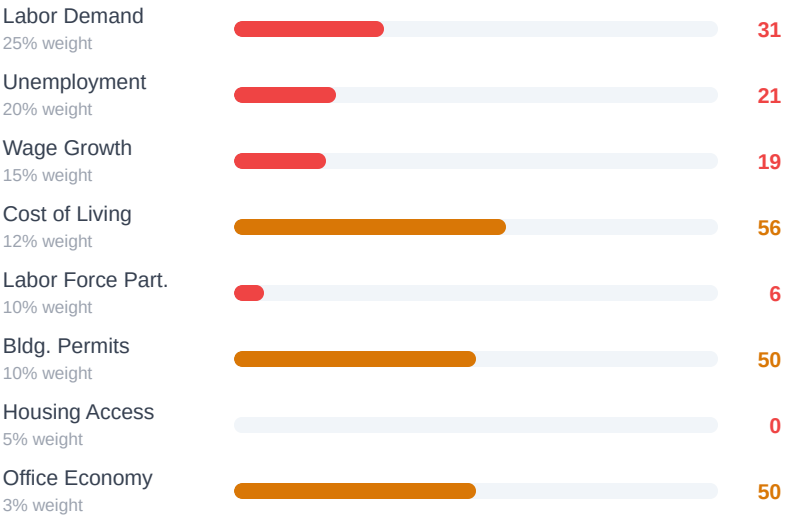
C-

CRITICAL

28.7th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Washington D.C. earns a C- overall grade, with its labor market challenges being the most significant concern. The city's unemployment rate of 3.80% signals labor market slack, and its civilian labor force is shrinking at a rate of -1.82% year-over-year, presenting a significant structural headwind for businesses seeking to expand headcount. Wage growth is stagnant, with hourly earnings increasing by only 1.90% year-over-year, which weakens local consumer demand.

The city's housing market is extremely competitive, with homes selling quickly, as indicated by its bottom-tier days on market score. This creates a challenge for new hires, who may face serious housing competition, affecting affordability and relocation decisions. The combination of a shrinking labor force and a highly competitive housing market creates a complex environment for businesses to navigate.

The city's labor market has slack, making it easier for businesses to hire, but this comes with significant risks, including a shrinking labor force and stagnant wage growth. The highly competitive housing market poses a relocation challenge, making it essential for businesses to carefully consider these factors when making location decisions, with a shrinking labor force and stagnant wage growth being key concerns.

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

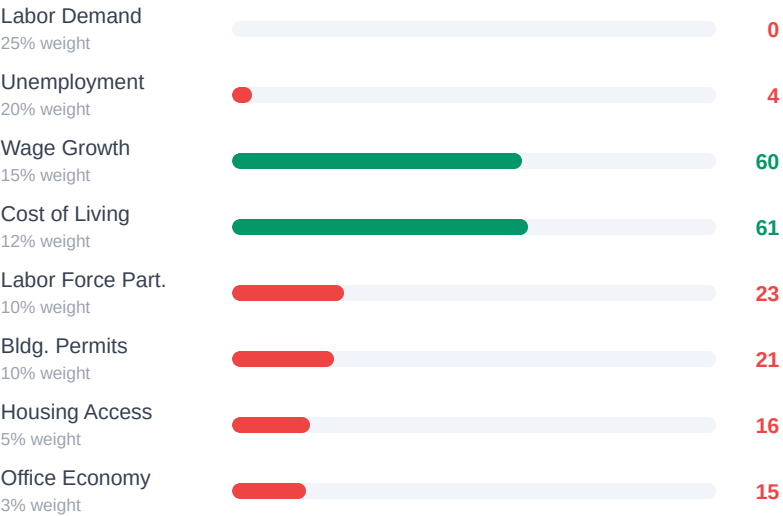
D

EMERGENCY

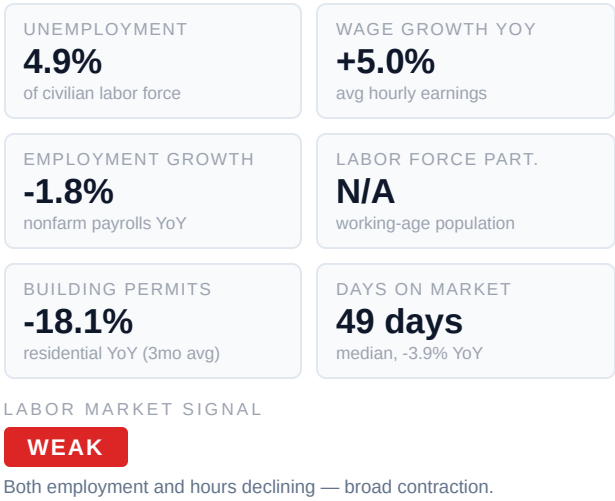
22.8th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area earns an overall grade of D, driven by severe labor market weakness. This weakness is characterized by an unemployment rate of 4.90% and a nonfarm employment growth rate of -1.84% year-over-year, indicating job losses and a contracting economy. The labor force is growing at a pace of +0.04% year-over-year, constraining hiring capacity.

The housing market is characterized by homes selling at a rapid pace, averaging 49 days on market, with a year-over-year decrease of -3.9% in days on market. However, building permits have declined by -18.14% year-over-year, indicating a supply contraction. The low office and professional worker share, ranking in the 15th percentile, poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses.

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro's severe labor market weaknesses and constrained housing supply pose significant risks to businesses. The city's competitive housing market and limited professional workforce may lead to talent attraction and retention challenges, making it essential for businesses to carefully weigh these factors in their location decision, considering the potential risks alongside any potential benefits.